USCIS Community App — PRD

Oct 31, 2026 · @Pablo \

Overview

Build an iOS app where immigrants ask questions about their USCIS cases and help each other, with every thread filed under the exact process it concerns (I-751, N-400, I-485 and so on). Working name: **CaseCircle** (placeholder).

Problem. People going through USCIS processes wait months with little visibility. They turn to r/USCIS, Facebook groups and WhatsApp chats to compare timelines, decode case status updates, and prepare for interviews. Those spaces are noisy: the same questions repeat daily, posts are hard to find by form type or service center, and nothing separates experienced members from guesswork.

Vision. A structured, mobile-first r/USCIS: every question lives inside its process, every member can attach an anonymized case profile (form, service center, field office, filing date), and the community's shared timelines become searchable data.

One-line pitch. "Find people on the same immigration path as you, and get answers from those a few steps ahead."

What we borrow from r/USCIS (from general familiarity with the subreddit; the page could not be fetched for this draft): process flairs on every post, timeline-update posts ("I-751 approved, 14 months, VSC"), case-status decoding questions, interview experience write-ups, and strong norms against sharing receipt numbers and other identifiers.

What we add: process-first navigation, structured case profiles, timeline data aggregated across members, reputation for helpful answers, and moderation built for App Store review.

Goals, non-goals and success metrics

The MVP succeeds if a new user finds their process, asks a question and gets a useful community answer within 24 hours.

Goals

1. Organize all community content by immigration process, so users only see what applies to them.

2. Get questions answered fast by peers who have been through the same process.
3. Turn shared timelines into useful, anonymized benchmarks ("median I-751 at your service center").
4. Keep the space safe, accurate and compliant with App Store and privacy rules.

Non-goals (MVP)

- Giving legal advice or matching users with lawyers.
- Filing or preparing forms for users.
- Pulling case status from USCIS on the user's behalf.
- Android and web (web read-only may follow; see Roadmap).
- Claiming or implying any affiliation with USCIS or the U.S. government.

Success metrics (first 6 months after launch)

Metric	Target	Why it matters
Questions with a first answer in 24 h	70%	Core promise of the app
Median time to first answer	< 4 h	Speed beats Reddit
D30 retention	25%	Cases last months; users should stay
Users with a case profile	50%	Fuels timelines and matching
Timeline updates posted per week	500	Data asset that grows the moat
Reports actioned within 24 h	95%	App Store 1.2 and trust
Answers marked helpful	40% of answers	Quality signal

Targets are starting assumptions to calibrate after the beta.

Target users and personas

The core user is an applicant in the middle of a long wait; the core contributor is someone who finished the same process recently.

Persona	Situation	Needs from the app
The waiting applicant	Filed I-751 14 months ago; status hasn't changed	"Is this normal?" Timelines from same service center, reassurance, next steps
The first-timer	About to file I-130/I-485 for a spouse	Checklists from others, which evidence worked, common mistakes
The interview-prepper	N-400 interview in 3 weeks	Field office experiences, civics test tips, what officers asked
The RFE recipient	Got a Request for Evidence	Others who got the same RFE and what they submitted
The veteran helper	Naturalized last year; enjoys helping	Reputation, a way to answer efficiently, recognition
The family supporter	Helping a parent through I-90 or N-400	Plain-language answers, Spanish support

Language. Launch in English and Spanish; Spanish is the largest non-English need in this audience.

Case taxonomy

Content is organized in three levels: **Category → Process (a "Space") → Tags**. Each Space maps to one primary USCIS form so members self-select precisely. Forms below follow the USCIS all-forms index as summarized by VisaVerge; the taxonomy is stored as data, not code, so new forms or programs are added without an app release.

Category	Space (process)	Primary form(s)
Citizenship	Naturalization	N-400 (+ N-648 disability exception, N-336 hearing, N-470)
Citizenship	Certificate of citizenship	N-600, N-600K, N-565 replacement
Family green card	Petition for relative	I-130, I-130A

Category	Space (process)	Primary form(s)
Family green card	Fiancé(e) visa	I-129F
Family green card	Widow(er) / special immigrant	I-360
Green card	Adjustment of status	I-485 (+ I-693 medical, I-864 affidavit)
Green card	Removal of conditions (marriage)	I-751
Green card	Green card renewal / replacement	I-90
Green card	Returning resident / abandonment	I-131 reentry permit, I-407
Employment	Immigrant worker petition	I-140 (EB-1, EB-2, EB-3, NIW)
Employment	Nonimmigrant worker	I-129 (H-1B, L-1, O-1, etc.)
Employment	Investor	I-526, I-526E, I-829
Work and travel	Work permit (EAD)	I-765 (by eligibility code: c9, c8, c11, etc.)
Work and travel	Advance parole / travel documents	I-131
Nonimmigrant status	Extend or change status	I-539
Humanitarian	Asylum (affirmative)	I-589
Humanitarian	Refugee / asylee relative	I-730
Humanitarian	TPS	I-821
Humanitarian	DACA	I-821D
Humanitarian	U visa / T visa / VAWA	I-918, I-914, I-360
Waivers	Inadmissibility waivers	I-601, I-601A, I-212
Adoption	Intercountry adoption	I-600, I-600A, I-800, I-800A
Cross-cutting	Fees, biometrics, online account, FOIA, premium processing	I-912, G-639, I-907
Cross-cutting	Consular stage (NVC, embassy interview)	DS-260 (Dept. of State, not USCIS)

Tags within every Space (filterable chips): stage (Filed, Biometrics, RFE, Interview scheduled, Interview done, Approved, Denied, Oath), service center or field office, filing method (online or paper), based-on (marriage, employment, etc.), and post type (Question, Timeline update, Interview experience, Tip, Vent).

Concurrent filings. Many users have several forms at once (I-485 + I-765 + I-131). A user can join multiple Spaces, and a post can be cross-tagged to up to three Spaces.

Core features (MVP)

The MVP is eight features; P0 ships at launch, P1 within the first month after.

#	Feature	Priority	User story
F1	Onboarding and Space selection	P0	As a new user, I pick my process(es) so my feed is relevant from minute one
F2	Case profile (anonymized)	P0	As an applicant, I add my form, filing date, service center and stage so others can compare
F3	Posts and Q&A	P0	As an applicant, I ask a question in the right Space and get answers
F4	Feed, search and filters	P0	As a user, I find past answers by form, stage and office before asking
F5	Timeline updates and benchmarks	P0	As an applicant, I see how long people at my service center are waiting
F6	Notifications	P0	As a poster, I'm told when someone answers me
F7	Moderation and safety	P0	As a member, I can report, block and trust that bad content is removed
F8	Reputation and helpers	P1	As a helper, I earn recognition; as an asker, I see who's reliable

F1. Onboarding and Space selection

- Sign in with Apple (required option), email magic link, Google.

- Pick a pseudonymous username; real names discouraged.
- Choose one or more Spaces from the taxonomy, with a search box ("I-751", "citizenship", "work permit").
- Accept community rules and the legal disclaimer (not legal advice; not USCIS).
- **Accept:** a new user reaches a populated Space feed in under 60 seconds.

F2. Case profile

- Per Space: form, based-on, filing date (month precision), service center or field office, filing method, current stage, stage dates.
- Shown as a compact badge on posts ("I-751 · VSC · filed Mar 2025 · Biometrics done").
- **Never** collects receipt numbers, A-numbers, full dates of birth, addresses or document images. Text fields are scanned for receipt-number patterns (3 letters + 10 digits) and A-numbers and blocked before posting.
- **Accept:** profile edit under 30 seconds; zero identifiers stored.

F3. Posts and Q&A

- Post types: Question, Timeline update, Interview experience, Tip, Vent.
- Rich text, up to 4 images (auto-blur check for documents; see Trust and safety), links.
- Threaded replies, upvotes, "Mark as helpful" by the asker, bookmark.
- Before posting a Question, show the top 3 similar past threads (dedupe).
- Edit window 24 h; deletion anytime by author.
- **Accept:** posting takes 3 taps after the text; duplicate suggestions appear for over 50% of questions after month 2.

F4. Feed, search and filters

- Home feed = posts from joined Spaces, sorted by New, Top (week), Unanswered.
- Filter chips by stage, office, post type.
- Full-text search across all Spaces with Space and tag facets.
- **Accept:** search results under 500 ms at p95.

F5. Timeline updates and benchmarks

- A Timeline update post auto-updates the author's case profile stage.

- Each Space shows aggregate stats from profiles: median and range of days between stages, by service center or field office, rolling 12 months.
- Show a stat only when at least 20 data points exist; label as community-reported, not official, and link to official USCIS processing times.
- **Accept:** stats recompute nightly; small-sample cells hidden.

F6. Notifications

- Push for: reply to my post, reply to my comment, my question marked solved, new post in a followed thread.
- Optional weekly digest per Space.
- **Accept:** user controls each type; default quiet hours 22:00 to 08:00 local.

F7. Moderation and safety (detail in Trust and safety)

- Report on every post, comment and profile; block user; content filter before publish; published contact info.
- **Accept:** meets all App Store Guideline 1.2 requirements before first submission.

F8. Reputation and helpers (P1)

- Points from helpful marks and upvotes; level badges per Space ("I-751 Helper").
- Optional "Completed this process" badge, self-attested.
- Verified professional badge for licensed attorneys and DOJ-accredited representatives, checked manually against bar records.

Post-MVP roadmap

After launch, the order is: deepen the data asset, then add official status tracking, then monetize.

Feature	What it does	Depends on
Case status tracking	User enters receipt number; app polls status and alerts on change. Receipt stays on-device or encrypted, never shown to others	USCIS Torch Case Status API production approval

Feature	What it does	Depends on
"People like me" matching	Find members with same form, office and filing month	5k+ case profiles
AI answer assist	Summarizes past community answers for a question, with links to threads and USCIS pages; always labeled "community summary, not legal advice"	Search index, legal review
Interview prep hub	Crowd-sourced field office interview reports, N-400 civics practice	F3 interview posts
Live office pages	Per field office: recent interview reports, oath ceremony dates	F5 data
Visa Bulletin and USCIS news alerts	Monthly bulletin and policy changes pushed to relevant Spaces	Content ops
More languages	Portuguese, Chinese, Hindi, Vietnamese, Tagalog	Moderator coverage per language
Android and web read-only	Reach and SEO from public threads	Stable API
Verified attorney Q&A (paid)	Attorneys answer flagged questions; user may book a consult	Legal and referral-fee compliance review

The USCIS Torch API requires a registered developer account, sandbox testing, and a live demo before production keys are issued (USCIS developer portal), so plan 1 to 3 months for that approval.

Trust, safety and legal

This is the section most likely to sink the app, so it is a launch gate, not a later polish item.

App Store requirements (Guideline 1.2, user-generated content)

Apple requires apps with user content to include a way to filter objectionable material, a way for users to report content, the ability to block abusive users, and published contact information (Vettly summary of 1.2). Apple revised the guidelines on Oct 16, 2026 and broadened the UGC definition (ConductAtlas diff), so re-read the current guidelines before submission.

- [ ] Server-side content filter before publish (toxicity, spam, scam links)
- [ ] Report button on every post, comment and profile
- [ ] Block user (hides their content both ways)
- [ ] Support email and contact page in app and on the App Store listing
- [ ] In-app account deletion
- [ ] Demo account and moderation admin notes in App Review Information

Not legal advice; not USCIS

- Disclaimer at onboarding, in every Space header, and under every answer: community experiences, not legal advice.
- Name, icon and screenshots must not use the DHS seal, USCIS logo or wording that implies government affiliation. App Store subtitle includes "Not affiliated with USCIS".
- Users cannot sell form-preparation services. Anyone offering paid help must be a verified attorney or DOJ-accredited representative; "notario" and "immigration consultant" solicitations are removed as likely fraud.
- Auto-detect posts that look like a fee demand or scam ("pay to expedite", gift cards, WhatsApp numbers) and hold them for review.
- Get a one-time review from an immigration attorney and a tech lawyer on terms, disclaimers and the AI feature before launch.

Privacy (this audience is high-risk)

- Pseudonymous by default; no real-name requirement; no public location finer than service center or field office.
- Block receipt numbers, A-numbers, passport numbers and SSNs in text; detect and require blurring of document images (OCR + manual review queue).
- Minimal collection: no contacts, no precise location, no ad-tracking SDKs. App Privacy label should read "Data Not Linked to You" wherever possible.

- Data retention and deletion policy published; account deletion removes profile and anonymizes posts.
- Plan how to respond to government data requests; publish a transparency report annually.

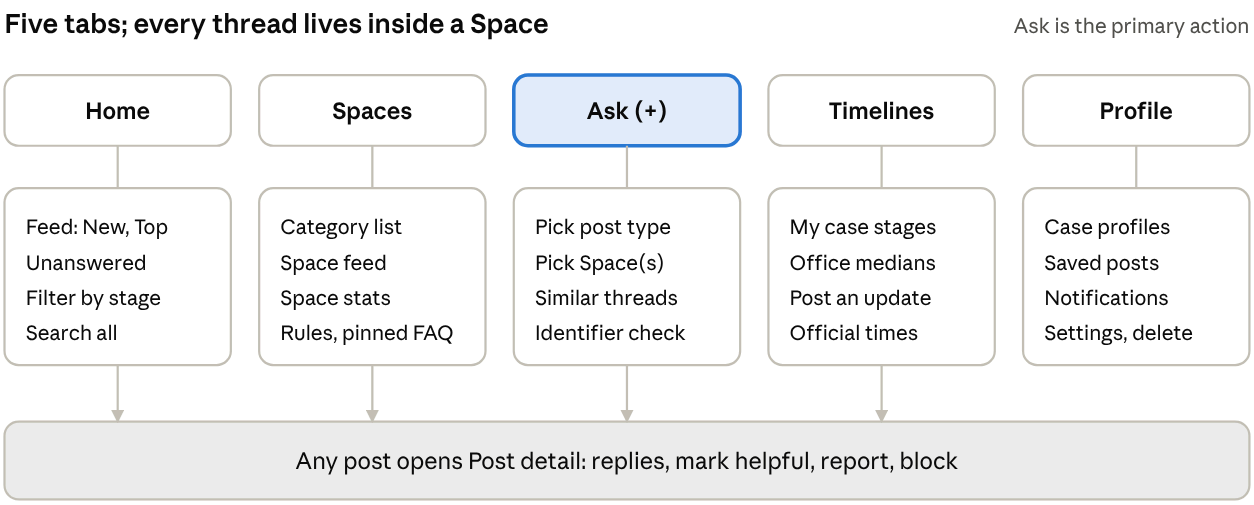
Moderation operations

Layer	How	Target
Automated filter	ML classifier + regex for identifiers and scams	Blocks before publish
Community	Reports; 3 reports auto-hides pending review	Hidden within minutes
Volunteer mods	Trusted helpers per Space, with mod tools	Review queue < 24 h
Staff	Appeals, legal, bans	95% of reports actioned < 24 h

Community rules: be kind, no identifiers, no paid solicitation, no misinformation presented as fact, no politics beyond how policy affects cases, Spanish and English both welcome.

Information architecture and key screens

Five bottom tabs, with Ask as the center primary action; every feed, Space and timeline leads into the same Post detail screen.



app navigation · 5 tabs, shared post detail

Key screen notes

- **Space page:** header with form numbers, member count, disclaimer; tabs for Feed, Stats (median days between stages by office), and FAQ.
- **Post card:** title, case badge ("I-485 · NBC · filed Jan 2026"), stage chip, reply count, solved check.
- **Ask flow:** type → Space → text → similar threads shown → identifier scan → publish.
- **Empty states:** every new Space shows pinned FAQ threads and a prompt to post a timeline.
- **Accessibility:** Dynamic Type, VoiceOver labels, full Spanish localization.

Technical architecture

Recommended: native SwiftUI client on a managed Postgres backend, so a solo founder or small team ships the MVP in about 12 weeks.

Layer	Choice	Why
iOS client	SwiftUI, iOS 17+	Native feel, fastest App Review path
Backend	Supabase (Postgres, Auth, Storage, Edge Functions)	Auth, row-level security and realtime out of the box
Search	Postgres full-text first; Typesense or Meilisearch at scale	Cheap start, faceted search later

Layer	Choice	Why
Moderation	OpenAI or Perspective-style classifier via Edge Function + regex identifier filter	Meets 1.2 filter requirement
Image safety	On-device Vision OCR to detect documents, server re-check	Blocks receipt notices and IDs
Push	APNs via OneSignal or direct	Reply alerts, digests
Analytics	PostHog (self-hostable, no ad tracking)	Privacy label stays clean
Admin	Retool or a simple web dashboard on Supabase	Mod queue, bans, taxonomy edits
Later	USCIS Torch Case Status API from server only	Torch keys must stay server-side

Core data model

Table	Key fields
users	id, username, locale, reputation, role (member, helper, mod, verified_pro), created_at
categories	id, name_en, name_es, sort
spaces	id, category_id, slug ("i-751"), name_en, name_es, primary_forms[], active
memberships	user_id, space_id, notify_level
case_profiles	id, user_id, space_id, based_on, filed_month, office_id, filing_method, current_stage, stage_dates jsonb
offices	id, type (service_center, field_office, nbc), code, name, state
posts	id, author_id, space_ids[], type, title, body, tags[], status (live, held, removed), helpful_answer_id
comments	id, post_id, parent_id, author_id, body, status

Table	Key fields
votes / helpful_marks	user_id, target_id, value
reports	id, reporter_id, target_type, target_id, reason, state, resolved_by
blocks	blocker_id, blocked_id
stage_stats (materialized)	space_id, office_id, from_stage, to_stage, n, p25, median, p75, window

Privacy by design: identifier regex runs both in the client (fast feedback) and in a database trigger (enforcement), and stage_stats never exposes a cell with n below 20.

Monetization, launch and risks

Keep the community free forever; earn from optional premium tools and vetted attorney referrals once trust is established.

Monetization

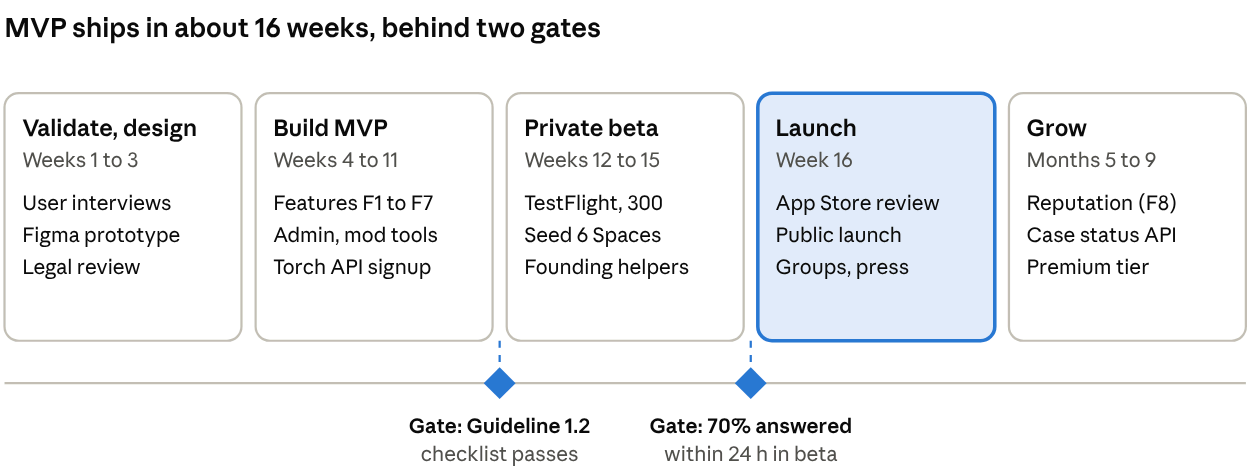
Stream	When	Notes
Free core	Always	Asking, answering, search, timelines
Premium (~$4.99/mo or $29.99/yr, via in-app purchase)	After 10k MAU	Case status alerts, advanced benchmarks by office, ad-free, priority AI summary
Verified attorney directory	After legal review	Attorneys pay for listing and verified badge; flat fee, not per-case referral fees, to avoid state bar issues
No ads at MVP	MVP	Ads in an immigration app attract scam advertisers

Digital features must use Apple in-app purchase (Guideline 3.1.1).

Launch plan

1. **Private beta (TestFlight):** 100 to 300 users recruited from immigration Facebook groups, Discord and personal network; seed each top Space with 20+ high-quality FAQ threads written from public USCIS sources.
2. **Seed helpers:** invite 20 to 50 experienced community members as founding helpers and moderators.
3. **Public launch:** top 6 Spaces first (N-400, I-751, I-485, I-130, I-765, I-131), others visible but marked "new".
4. **Growth:** public web read-only threads for SEO, share-a-timeline cards for social, App Store search terms like "green card tracker" and "citizenship".

Milestones



roadmap · 5 phases, 2 gates

Week counts assume one experienced iOS developer plus a part-time designer; the beta does not start until the moderation checklist passes, and launch waits for the answer-speed target.

Risks

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
App Store rejection for UGC or implied government affiliation	Launch delay	Full 1.2 checklist, neutral branding, demo account for reviewers

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
Cold start: empty Spaces	Users leave	Seeded FAQs, focus on 6 Spaces, founding helpers
Bad advice causes harm	Trust and legal exposure	Disclaimers, helpful-marking, verified pros, misinformation reports
Scammers and notarios	User harm	Scam filter, no paid solicitation, fast bans
Privacy breach or identifiers leaked	Severe harm to users	Identifier blocking, pseudonymity, minimal data, security review
Competitors (Reddit, Lawfully, case-tracker apps)	Slow growth	Process-first structure and timeline benchmarks Reddit lacks
Policy volatility	Content goes stale	News alerts, stage tags, date-stamped threads

Open questions

- [ ] Final app name and domain (check trademark; avoid "USCIS" in the name).
- [ ] Launch in English only, or English + Spanish on day one?
- [ ] Include consular processing (NVC, DS-260) in MVP or later?
- [ ] Solo build, agency, or hire an iOS developer?
- [ ] Budget for legal review and moderation staffing.

Sources

- Apple App Store Review Guidelines
- Guideline 1.2 requirements summary (Vettly)
- Oct 2026 App Store guideline changes (ConductAtlas)
- USCIS Torch API developer portal
- USCIS forms index summary (VisaVerge)
- r/USCIS (not fetchable for this draft; described from general familiarity)